



“The Nexus team are amazing people that go the extra mile to guide and support your startup’s journey. The program was a great learning experience that fine-tuned my understanding of the startup process. My biggest takeaways were to stay focused, visualise, plan and act. Training in market validation, pitching, funding, and sales processes have been inspiring and it gave me renewed focus to continue building my innovation i-PanelKlean nA2 (a waterless solar panel self-cleaning system)”.



Sameer Malik, Program Manager, Nexus

Before the Covid-19 pandemic, the Nexus Startup Hub registered a lot of interest in their program even outside Delhi, however, due to the physical nature of their course, many startups originating outside Delhi were unable to attend the sessions. The onset of the pandemic gave Nexus an opportunity to promote their program to startups outside the Delhi-NCR region as well. The first online cohort (Cohort 10) comprised of 66 per cent startups that were outside Delhi, which is the highest they’ve recorded so far.

TRANSFORMING THE MODEL

Nexus faced an uphill battle to not only cover the entire curriculum online but also integrate crucial elements of community building, peer learning, and networking into their online sessions that come much more naturally in a physical setup. Moreover, Nexus wanted to ensure that the online cohort was as much a part of their community of startups and peer groups as the offline graduated startups were. To ensure this Nexus implemented the following methods:

INOVIEA (COHORT 8)

Noida-based Inoviea Consulting & Services is a technical, management, marketing consulting and services company that has invented a novel patented technology that enhances the efficiency of solar panels. The technology termed i-PanelKlean nA2 is a completely waterless solar panel automated-cleaning system that enhances overall electricity production. It is a fixed solution that keeps solar panels clean without the need for any manual interference. It’s a two-fold cleaning solution – slippery nanocoatings are applied on solar panels in solar plants (existing or new) that prevent dust from sticking to them and compressed air is used to blow dust away from the panels multiple times a day. The process does away with the use of water completely for cleaning solar panels and also increases the overall power generation from anywhere between 30 to 100 per cent. Suchin Jain, Founder, Inoviea Consulting & Services stated, “We focus on developing niche and indigenous solutions in solar. There is a large impact of “i-panelKlean nA2” technology that has per GW per annum potential to generate extra power worth 80 million, save 1 billion litres of water, reduce carbon emissions up to about 600,000 tons, save 100-150 lives of Roofers (sixth most dangerous job in the world) in the US alone, and world over total solar rooftop segment is over 100 Gigawatts”.



The first solar power plant set up by the startup was a hybrid solution which generated almost 5 units/kW annual average in Noida. In contrast, other plants in similar locations produced only 2.4 to 4 units, according to Jain. The startup also worked on converting a diesel-powered boat to a solar-charged e-boat to reduce water pollution in river Ganga. The e-boat, which is allegedly India’s first e-boat, was launched by Prime Minister Narendra Modi in May 2016. Jain said, “In my journey of sustainability and growth, I soon realised that it was my passion for innovation that had won”. As a naval architect who served in the Indian navy, Jain’s experience as a warship designer helped him through his entrepreneurial journey. He also utilised his expertise in technology and design to innovate high-tech solutions such as the i-PanelKlean nA2, an Office Management System app, and even a Touchless Intelligent Disinfection Gate to fight Covid-19.

- Encouraging people to keep their videos on during online sessions to promote higher levels of engagement
- Organising short, fun activities during the first week of training to increase engagement and break barriers
- All ACIR team members also keep their video on during online sessions to lead by example
- Scattered Q+A sessions during presentations that ensured that the participants (even those who didn’t turn their videos on) are engaged and present
- Keeping Zoom chat rooms open even after official sessions to pro-